

Some of the best learning doesn't happen in a classroom — it happens in a room full of whiteboards, cold coffee, and a deadline ticking down. That's exactly what the Philtech Innovathon for Universities was for me and my team.

Assembling the Team



January 22, 2025 — Together with my hackathon mates, Aljen Carmona, Josephus Romero, Samuel Sarmiento, and Noah Catungan, we first assembled at school, since this was our designated pick-up location. There's a particular kind of excitement in that moment before a hackathon starts — you don't know exactly what's ahead, but you know it's going to be a long, intense couple of days.

The Challenge: Mental Health and Wellness



Once we arrived, Philtech introduced the company, walked us through the mechanics, and had us draw lots to determine our presentation order. Then came the topic we'd be tackling: personal productivity and wellness. The prompt was blunt and important — *"Mental health concerns have become evident with the youth. What breakthroughs can be introduced to assist and provide appropriate intervention?"*

This was where we spent the bulk of our time. With a question that big, the ideas came fast and kept overflowing — almost too many possible directions to choose from. Narrowing it down to one solid concept took real discussion and some hard calls.

Locking In: Development Phase



Once we settled on what app or prototype to build, along with its core features, we split up to work on our individual roles. I was tasked with the front end together with Samuel, and together we designed the UI of the prototype. This was the "lock-in" period — heads down, screens glowing, everyone quietly grinding through their part of the build.

Fuel for the Grind



Food and coffee!! I was honestly surprised by how well-fed we were. There wasn't a single moment during the entire competition where we went hungry — which, if you've ever been through a hackathon, you know makes a bigger difference than people expect.

Pitch Day



January 23, 2026 — Pitching time! This part was nerve-wracking, since we were the first school to present our project in front of Philtech's general manager, Trung Nguyen, and other department heads. Presenting a project centered on mental health to that kind of audience raised the stakes, but it also reminded us why the work mattered in the first place.

[IMAGE: Team presenting on stage with dashboard shown on large screen] [IMAGE: Two side-by-side photos — team posing in front of Innovathon banner, and team seated together at their workstation]

And That's a Wrap



This was a genuinely great experience for me. I'd like to give a huge thanks to our mentors, Ms. Nila Santiago and Ms. Paula Mendoza, for their all-out support throughout the event. They shared their personal experiences from joining hackathons themselves, which gave us much better direction on what to focus on. I'd also like to thank Philtech for the opportunity — they were incredibly accommodating and even provided a workshop before the event that helped prepare us going in.

Walking away from this, I didn't just come out with a working prototype. I came out with a better sense of how to turn a broad, difficult problem into something buildable in a short amount of time, and how much a supportive team and good mentorship can make that process feel less overwhelming.

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